

BEFORE TOMORROW

Bath & The Romans

We won't have a lesson before the trip, so read this whenever you can — on the coach, tonight, whenever. Ten minutes is enough.

Where are we going?

Bath is a city in England, famous for its old golden-stone buildings and, most of all, for something the Romans built almost 2,000 years ago: a huge bathing complex fed by a natural hot spring.

In the morning, we'll visit the **Roman Baths museum**. In the afternoon, a guided tour continues the Roman theme around the city.

The Romans and the magic water

Long before the Romans arrived, local people believed a goddess called **Sulis** lived in a spring of hot water that bubbled up from the ground. When the Romans came, they connected Sulis to their own goddess, **Minerva** — so the site became sacred to **Sulis Minerva**, goddess of wisdom.

Fun fact: the spring water comes out of the ground at **46°C** — hotter than the bath you take at home!

The Romans built a temple and bathing complex around the spring. People travelled long distances to bathe there, pray to the goddess, and ask her for help.

Fun fact: Romans threw coins, jewellery, and even little notes into the water as gifts to the goddess. Some notes asked her to punish

someone who had stolen something from them — we call these **curses!**

Key words

hot spring

hot water from the ground

temple

a building for worship

goddess

a female god

coin

metal money

statue

a stone/metal figure

ancient

very, very old

ruins

what's left of old buildings

bath / pool

where the Romans bathed

Quick check

Circle True or False for each one.

1. The hot spring water is colder than your bath at home.

☐ True

☐ False

2. The goddess of the spring is called Sulis Minerva.

☐ True

☐ False

3. Romans threw coins into the spring as gifts to the goddess.

☐ True

☐ False

4. The Roman Baths were built about 100 years ago.

☐ True

☐ False

For stronger students

A few extra details you can look out for and mention in the debrief tomorrow:

- **Aquae Sulis** — the Roman name for Bath. It means "the waters of Sulis."
- **Curse tablets** — notes to the goddess, written on thin sheets of lead, sometimes written backwards so only she could read them.
- **The Gorgon's head** — a huge stone carving of a face with a moustache, above the entrance to the temple. Nobody is completely sure who it represents.

- **Hypocaust** — the Roman underfloor heating system: hot air moved under raised floors to heat the rooms.

Tomorrow, look out for as many of these things as you can — you'll get a scavenger hunt to help. We'll compare notes in the debrief the day after!